

**LISTENING
#22****Teacher's Guide****SCRIPT: THE DARK SIDE OF AVOCADOS**

Presenter: The humble avocado has become something of a celebrity in the food world. And its popularity has seen a massive boom in farmers growing them, largely in Mexico. Though it still features prominently on the Instagram feeds of so-called foodies, some have started to turn away from the versatile fruit. Keith Adams went to find out why.

Adams (reporter): The trendy cafes here on Broadway Market in East London have embraced the avocado. On toast, in salads, or in that Mexican staple guacamole. It's a fashionable food. Global avocado production doubled over the last 20 years. And consumption in the US has doubled in the last decade. But now some chefs are turning away, citing its impact on the environment. Popular Mexican restaurants in the UK, US, and Canada are offering guacamole made from peas or courgettes or Jerusalem artichokes instead. So what's the problem? Some reports suggest a single avocado needs hundreds of liters of water to grow. Anonor Eldridge from the conservation charity Plant Life says that's a big issue.

Eldridge: So they're a really thirsty crop. And primarily avocados are grown in Mexico, which if anyone's been there knows it's quite a warm place already and is experiencing quite a lot of water stress.

Adams: What about the growers who grow them? Are they caring for the environment?

Eldridge: The average worker on a plantation growing avocados and sixty dollars a day. The minimum wage in Mexico is five dollars a day. What that means is more and more land is converted over into avocado production, pushing into areas that were previously native or previously forested. And so that's having an impact on the biodiversity in the environment.

Adams: I'm in a chic Mexican fusion restaurant in London. It's called Cole. And the proprietor and chef, Santiago Lastra, is preparing something. What is it, Santiago?

Santiago: So we're doing a guacamole, but made out of pistachio instead of avocado.

Adams: Santiago says it's not just the environmental impact of avocados that led him to drop them. Another reason is the link to organized crime. Falco Ernst works for the International Crisis Group in Mexico City.

Ernst: I first introduced myself with drugs traffickers who had gone into the avocado business 10 years ago basically. So it's been going on for quite a while now. And along the way, there have been a lot of casualties. Families who've had to flee producers. Families who've had to flee for instance to the United States because they have been forced out. And direct physical violence has been applied. In the context of groups of trying to squeeze protection payments out of producers, which has brought disappearances. Family members, workers have gotten killed. So the cost has been huge.

Answer Key

Comprehension Activity

1. b) As a food world celebrity
2. Mexico
3. b) They have fully embraced them
4. c) Their environmental impact
5. b) Peas and courgettes
6. b) They require large amounts of water
7. b) Connections to organized crime
8. b) Families have had to flee and people have been killed

Reading Comprehension

1. Because of social media trends, cafés, and its association with healthy eating.
2. High water use, deforestation, pressure on natural habitats and water supplies.
3. Threats, land seizures, violence, and families being forced to leave.

Idioms

“something of a celebrity” = very famous or fashionable

“turning away” = rejecting or abandoning something

“drop them” = stop using something completely

“booming trade” = a rapidly expanding market